



Comoros

Off the east African coast, between Mozambique and Madagascar, lies the archipelago republic of the Comoros, comprising three main islands and a number of smaller islets.



GEOGRAPHY

Main islands are of volcanic origin and are heavily forested. The remainder are coral atolls.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid all year round, especially on the coasts. November to May is hottest and wettest period.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Comoros has absorbed a diversity of people over the years, including Africans, Arabs, Polynesians, and Persians. There have also been Portuguese, Dutch, French, and Indian immigrants. Ethnic discord is rare, but regional tensions between islands are marked. The country is politically unstable and there have been frequent coups. A fragile new federal system has been in place since 2002. Wealth is concentrated within a political and business elite.



THE ECONOMY

One of the world's poorest countries. Subsistence-level farming. Vanilla and cloves are main cash crops. Lack of basic infrastructure.



INSIGHT: *The Comoros is the world's largest producer of ylang-ylang – an extract from tree blossom used in manufacturing perfumes*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Union of the Comoros

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Moroni

POPULATION: 676,000

TOTAL AREA: 838 sq. miles
(2170 sq. km)

DENSITY: 785 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Comoran*, French*

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 98%, Roman Catholic 1%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Comoran 97%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Comoros franc = 100 centimes